Winter, 2003 Volume V, Issue 2

The Mountainside

Coolfont Mountainside Association

P.O. Box 418, Berkeley Springs, WV 25411



New Year, New Newsletter!

It had to happen sooner or later! As we begin 2003, "The Mountainside" not only has a fresh look, but contains more information you might find useful and interesting.

Leading off our new publication is a thorough survey of the wildlife on our mountainside by long-time owner and former board member and CMA president Elmer Broxson. Share it with family and visitors!



Jackson Bain

We've also included new updates to our CMA member's list, and with new folks joining our community—and old friends departing—this feature remains very important, kept up-to-date by board member Joan Bradfield.

Treasurer Paul Kagen gives us his review of our financial condition *(good)*, Elmer Broxson also writes about our vital water supply, President Richard Kaufman shares his thoughts, and Bob Borchers, CMA's wonderful webmaster, urges you to visit and communicate using the newly redesigned CMA website—better known as **www.coolfontmountainside.org.**

Finally , we are including more graphics—including photos and drawings—to illustrate our articles, along with photos of board members, so you'll know 'em when you see 'em! *(Be nice: they're volunteers!)*

We hope you enjoy the new Newsletter, *(which seems to have picked up a new CMA mascot on the pages)* and if you have comments or suggestions—or especially if you have a story, observation or interesting fact to share, contact Jackson Bain at 703 549 –9592 or at **jackson@bainpr.com**! Enjoy!

Jackson Bain

CMA Board Meetings and Potluck Dinners!

February 15
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Open
March 15
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Open
April 19
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Barn
May 17
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Barn
June 14
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Barn
July 19
Board: CMA Office
ANNUAL MEETING:
Treetops Lodge
Annual Dinner: Barn

Recreation Committee to Address Swimming Pool and Tennis Courts



Marie Barrett

Marie Barrett, Chair of the Recreation Committee reports that the CMA has two major recreation projects under study this year.

The first is the review of code-required upgrades and changes to the swimming pool and its operation. She is determining the extent of those changes, which may include the hiring of a certified pool management company to insure compliance with state regulations.

The tennis court repair proposals are being analyzed by the committee, to determine how much money needs to be budgeted for those repairs, and the actual value to CMA homeowners.

Most homeowners responding to Marie's survey last year said they would use repaired tennis courts.

Special Feature!

Wildlife on the Mountainside

By Elmer Broxson

Editor's note: Our community is blessed with an enormous resource of knowledge and experience, and we will sample from that rich well in future issues of the newsletter. This issue, we asked longtime resident Elmer Broxson to give us a survey of some of the more frequently-seen mountainside wildlife, in a form that would be useful to homeowners and visitors, and even to be shared with children and grandchildren! Here is his report:



Bluebird

One of the main attractions of owning a house at Coolfont is the opportunity to observe the area's wildlife. We have sought to increase the Bluebird population by establishing a Bluebird Trail four years ago. The trail consists of 30 nesting boxes, which are maintained by Charlie Balkan and myself. About half the boxes are used by Bluebirds and most of the rest by Tree Swallows.



Woodpecker

A much more common bird on the mountainside is the pigeon-sized Pileated Woodpecker. It will invite itself to your house in search of the carpenter bee larvae in the woodwork. In summer, a couple of bats "hang out" during the day under my deck and, as you know, keep the insect population down by eating their weight in insects each nights. I plan to install a bat-box to keep them coming by.

A rare but rewarding encounter is with the Wild Turkey flocks which come and go and sometimes nest on the ground. I once disturbed a turkey hen on her nest only 30 feet from my house and, while looking for the Salmon Well several years ago, rescued a turkey chick from my dog, as the mother sought to lead us away from her nest by pretending to be lame.



Red-tailed Hawk

The Red-tailed Hawk also nests here in the trees. Their courting "sky-dives" are spectacular.

As might be expected there is a lot of activity in and around the lagoon (located in the CMA pasture). It is a frequent stopping over place for migrating Mallards, Canada Geese and Loons while Cranes and Herons often patrol its banks in search of frogs.

Muskrats also like the banks for digging their burrows, but since they weaken the dike that forms the south side of the lagoon, we largely depend on the Red-tailed hawk to keep their numbers in check.

As for mammals, the mountainside and the adjoining Cacapon State Park shelter creatures in size from field mice and chipmunks to the occasional visit by Black Bears. In between are the squirrels, opossums, raccoons and of course, Bambi! You don't want to find mice and squirrels in your house, opossum and raccoons in your trash cans and certainly not Black Bears on your deck (as the both Bigelows and the Waters did in recent years).

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CMA January Board Meeting Snapshots



President Richard Kaufman (foreground) makes a point as (left to right) CMA Ops Manger John Hobday, Treasurer Paul Kagen, DACC Chair Jim Thompson, Recreation Chair Marie Barrett and CMA member Joe Auslander listen in respectful silence!



(L to R): Joan Bradfield, Richard Kaufman, Jim Chiriaco, Paul Kagen, Marie Barrett, John Hobday and Elmer Broxson at the January Board meeting

The President's Column



Richard Kaufman

The Big Snow Job

Neither snow nor sleet nor rain nor cold could stop many of us from enjoying ourselves on the mountainside during the holidays. The weather was mostly brisk although New Year's Eve, of all days, was mild enough for friends to spend time on our deck gazing at the stars. The surroundings were especially picturesque, covered with a thin blanket of snow from Christmas Eve on

Neither did the snow deter the operator of Coolfont's snow plow, who could be seen from day to day on one road or driveway or another. Many of us wish that it had – deterred him, that is. It seems that he did not know how to properly remove snow without removing what lies beneath the snow or alongside it.

Several people registered complaints at the January meeting of the board of directors about snow removal excesses following the Christmas Eve snowfall. Virtually all the gravel was removed, together with the snow, from a section of our road that had been recently crowned and graveled. A number of private driveways were similarly mistreated. What is worse, some of the driveways were plowed without permission of the owners.

This prompted the board to direct that an e-mail be sent to the membership requesting that anyone who experienced similar problems notify us. So far, about 20 homeowners have responded. Typically, the snow and gravel was removed down to the dirt and shoved in a pile to the bottom of the driveway or to the top, blocking entry to the front door. One person said that some metal rods alongside his driveways were removed together with the gravel. Another said a large amount of gravel was pushed into his wife's garden.

We realize that not everyone has e-mail and we are trying to contact all homeowners about this. If you, or a neighbor, had problems with the snow removal during the holidays, or since then, please let us know. The Coolfont management, with whom we have a snow removal agreement, has been advised about the problem and we want to make sure they get the full story.

Richard F. Kaufman

The Water Column

By Elmer Broxson, Chair



Elmer Broxson

If you have read the local weekly newspaper, the Morgan Messenger, any time since last October, you will have noticed the on-going discussion of the future of the only public water system in the county, the Berkeley Springs Water Works. Because of the pollution of private wells- mainly by private septic systems- there is an increasing demand for BSWW to become a county-wide system. Coolfont Resort will become a customer after BSWW completes a reservoir on Warm Springs Ridge on land donated by the Resort. CMA has been assured that this reservoir will be filled by BSWW-supplied water and not from the aquifer which serves CMA.

Because its water source is a spring- not wells like CMA- and therefore subject to surface contamination, BSWW has recently been required to install an expensive filtration system. In addition, the existing distribution system in town is over 100 years old and in need of extensive repairs. Faced with these three serious financial demands the town government (which runs the system) is considering an offer by a private company, the West Virginia American Water Company, to either buy the BSWW or at least contract to manage it.

The WVAWC already owns the water systems of West Virginia's largest cities, the capital, Charleston and Huntington, on the Ohio River. Buying BSWW would give the company access to the Eastern Panhandle, the fastest-growing part of the state. In the event that BSWW is sold, we are assured by West Virginia state officials that we, and other private water systems, would not be required to become part of the new system. At present, the CMA board does not think it is in our interest to become part of BSWW whether publicly or privately-owned. We will continue to follow these developments.



From the Treasurer: CMA Finances are Sound

By Paul Kagen



Paul Kagen

At the half way point in our fiscal year the financial condition of CMA is in great shape as is that of the CMA Water and Sewer system.

With regard to the CMA budget, I can report that all assessments except one have been paid and overall we have collected over 98% of the income budgeted for the year. Our expenses have been well controlled in all areas of the budget. With the temporary postponement of capital improvement of our roads, pending a study now underway, the $14,000 budgeted for road improvements has been placed in reserve for future use. I anticipate that all expense budget items will end the year either under budget or within a reasonable range. The cash position of the Association remains strong. I cannot foresee, at this time, that a special assessment will be needed for any potential project on the mountainside.

With regard to the Water and Sewer budget, I can report that in the half year we have collected 54% of our annual income budget and we have spent only 36% of our budget. With the coming of Spring, I fully expect to see a substantial increase in expenses as we implement a program of installing meters to segment the system in a major attempt to identify and control water leaks. I anticipate that all Water and Sewer expense items will end the year either under budget or within a reasonable range. The cash position of the Water and Sewer system remains strong. I believe it is possible that the Public Service Commission will approve a reduction in Water rates in the near future once our water leak problems are brought under control.

I want to thank those members who make my job a pleasure by paying their assessments and water bills in a timely manner. I am concerned that after each quarter's water bill is rendered, approximately 10-20 members have not pay on time. Not only does it cost them a 10% penalty, but it makes the job of the Treasurer more time consuming. Despite the short (20 days) due date for payment which was imposed on us by the Public Service Commission of West Virginia, I urge each of you to pay promptly, thereby avoiding the penalty and making me happy.



Black Bear

These unpleasantries are fairly easy to avoid. For mice and squirrel problems, regularly check the eves and foundations for holes, and always keep leaves away from the house. Leaving dead trees standing gives the squirrels (and birds) nesting sites, which they prefer to your house!

To keep opossums and raccoons out of your trashcans, empty them promptly and until they are, keep the cans in sturdy bins covered with hardware cloth. While you can't keep bears out of the trash bins (if the cans are filled) you can keep them off your deck by not placing birdfeeders there. Bears are not interested in you as food, but IN your food (including bird food). Place the feeder away from the house, but close enough to be observed. Mine is outside the kitchen window, so while I cook and wash dishes, I can watch the squirrels and raccoons eat my bird food!



Raccoon



Opossum

And what about Bambi? It is the largest animal you're likely to see (until the Eastern Elks find their way through the Appalachians up from Kentucky and down from Pennsylvania where they have been re-introduced. Deer are common on the mountainside because both the lands of CMA and the State Park are wildlife refuges. However, hunting is allowed to our North (where the Ashelman family leases hunting rights on their land to a hunting club), and to the South.

If you want to observe deer-does, (since adult males rarely appear), you will have to attract them with food and salt. Both are available from the Southern States stores. I get Reliance Horse Feed in 50-pound bags for $6 each and 4-pound salt bricks for $2. For a deer feeder, a recycle bin works well, since it has holes in the bottom to keep the feed from becoming water logged. The "starving times" for deer are winter and early spring, so that's when they will frequent your feeder. In summer, they dress in a bright tan coat, which is changed in late fall to the gorgeous light gray winter wear. Also at this time they bring their fawns with them– after the fawns have lost most of their camouflage spots. I have two special does I watch for – a yearling who has lost her right front leg– probably in an auto accident – and an adult with a pronounced limp. Without such special features, it is nearly impossible to tell them apart.



Deer Doe

Is it wrong to feed the deer and get them used to humans? Remember, they have taken refuge in our wildlife sanctuary and, as territorial animals, learn to distinguish safe from dangerous places. Even so, they are always very wary when near houses and will flee at the first sound. They have extremely good hearing, smell and sight, so you'll have to turn out lights and be very still if you want o observe them from your house. In my view, the effort is well worth making. It takes only 10 to 15 minutes for a herd of 10 to 20 does to silently appear outside your window, and then take turns– one by one – at your feeder. It is good to always remember that the wildlife on the mountainside were here thousands of years before Europeans came, so actually we're the intruders, not them. We live in the woods– a perfect, beautiful place for people who admire and respect wildlife.

CORRECTIONS TO THE CMA 2002-2003 DIRECTORY

Add for I-4
James Applebaum and Laurie Mufson
300 E. Seminary Street
Mercersburg, PA 17236
717-328-2471

Michael Barrett-E-mail address: mbarrett@liuna.org

Mark Borinsky-E-mail address: mborinsk@jhmi.edu

Remove Bowers

Remove Ethan Burger and Neva Grant

Add for Q-4:
Dennis & Evelyn Brydges
2 Coolfont
Berkeley Springs, WV 25411
Coolfont phone: 304-258-0146
(Winter address or when not on Mountainside)
10 Deerfield CT., Palm Coast, FL 32137
Florida phone: 904-445-2408
Cell phone: 703-731-4305
email: dennybrydges@aol.com
EOBrydges@aol.com

Remove Sherry Cameron



Remove Travis Clark

Add for E-4:
Coolfont Development Corporation
3621 Cold Run Valley Road
Berkeley Springs, WV 25411

New address for the Corbeys
604 Mannakee St.
Rockville, MD 20850

Add for P-1
Andrew & Maryann Fialdini
11963 Grey Squirrel Lane
Reston, VA 20194
703-318-0127
E-mail:
and
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Reston, VA 20194
703-481-1534
E-mail:

Remove Arleigh Greenblatt

Add for Q-7:
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Work telephone: 410-935-7665
Work FAX 1-866-422-1885
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New address for the Kasemans
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Boyds, MD 20841

Add for N-6:
Terry and Marsha Moore
1346 Washington Dr.
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E-mail: TMoore9261@aol.com

Add for Q-3:
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phone 301-261-6187

Kathy Steinberg-E-mail address:
Knewman@muu.edu

D-7 New name and address:
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Ashburn, VA 20146
Work phone: 703-771-6570,
Coolfont phone: 304-258-7901

Ken Sachs/Judy Grasso-
E-mail address: kfsachs@comcast.net

HOST A CMA POTLUCK DINNER!

It's fun, easy and a *great* way to meet your Coolfont neighbors!
Contact Joan Bradfield
(301) 984-9657
for more Information!